FOREWORD

Only a handful of international cricketers have seen their personal popularity extend beyond the boundaries of their homeland. AB de Villiers can be included in this very select group of globally acclaimed superstars.

It was during the 2015 Indian Premier League when, together with other members of the coaching staff of the Mumbai Indians, we watched AB destroy our bowling attack and win the game for Royal Challengers Bangalore. He was batting for the visiting side, but the Mumbai crowd – our supporters – chanted his name before every single delivery that he faced.

'ABD! ABD! ABD! ABD! ABD!'

The chant rang around the entire stadium. I had heard an Indian crowd chant before, but not like this. It was freaky.

AB's innings was extraordinary, full of amazing footwork, brilliant strokes and brilliant improvisation. I was sitting beside my fellow Mumbai coach Ricky Ponting, watching in awe, and when it was all over the former Australian captain turned to me and pointed out that each of AB's shots had been played into a gap.

'That's not luck,' he said. 'That is genius.'

I arrived back at our hotel, somewhat grumpy after our heavy defeat. My wife, Melanie, who had watched on TV, observed: 'Oh well, it must